election campaigns in these townships, these cannot fully account for the fact that in all four southern townships it gained less than thirty per cent of the valid votes.[6] Contrasting the results here to the ANP's share of more than sixty-seven per cent of votes in Sittwe District, a fault line based on ethno-nationalism clearly exists between the northern and southern townships of the state. Despite shared ethnicity, the voting patterns in these townships show that the political sentiments of the Rakhine ethnic group are, in fact, deeply divided.

ANP AS THE BUDDHIST–NATIONALIST ALTERNATIVE

The NLD election victory nationwide surprised MaBaTha leaders, who had openly called for lay supporters not to vote for the NLD (Vogt and Khin Su Wai 2015). Since Myanmar monks are not allowed to vote (or participate formally in politics), MaBaTha office holders did not participate in the election. They could only persuade the lay people to vote for those who would champion their Buddhist-nationalist aspirations.

The central premise of MaBaTha's Buddhist nationalism is that Buddhism in Myanmar is under threat from a Muslim takeover, and the Buddhist community and the government must defend the religion and nation (Walton and Hayward 2014). While this position rests on the fear of Islam, MaBaTha arguments are articulated in terms of cosmological imageries embedded in Buddhist morality, juxtaposed with simplistic readings of global and regional terrorist events (Gravers 2015). However, the articulation of Buddhist morality is not only limited to the communal arguments championed by MaBaTha. Most Myanmar Buddhists would also view other socio-political issues through the lens of personal morality. Gravers points out that in fact "violence, corruption, drugs, gambling, prostitution, and socio-economic decline are seen as problems that can only be repaired by new moral subjects (and leaders) who are able to uproot their moral defilements" (2013, p. 48). From the perspective of Burmese Buddhists, the notion of Buddhist morality is not just about the defence of the religion from other religions, but also about how socio-economic reforms should be conducted.

The ruling party, the USDP, had failed in presenting itself as credible on socio-economic reforms by the standards of Buddhist morality. It had pitched for re-election citing its reform credentials (Barron and Swan Ye